

Option P4: Superpower relations and the Cold War, 1941–91

Key topic 1: The origins of the Cold War, 1941–58

1 Early tension between East and West	• The Grand Alliance. The outcomes of the Tehran, Yalta and Potsdam conferences. • The ideological differences between the superpowers and the attitudes of Stalin, Truman and Churchill. • The impact on US-Soviet relations of the development of the atomic bomb, the Long and Novikov telegrams and the creation of Soviet satellite states in Eastern Europe.
2 The development of the Cold War	• The impact on US-Soviet relations of the Truman Doctrine and the Marshall Plan, 1947. • The significance of Cominform (1947), Comecon (1949) and the formation of NATO (1949). • Berlin: its division into zones. The Berlin Crisis (blockade and airlift) of 1948-49 and its impact. The formation of the Federal Republic of Germany and German Democratic Republic.
3 The Cold War intensifies	• The significance of the arms race. The formation of the Warsaw Pact. • Events in 1956 leading to the Hungarian Uprising, and Khrushchev's response. • The international reaction to the Soviet invasion of Hungary.

Key topic 2: Cold War crises, 1958–70

1 Increased tension between East and West	• The refugee problem in Berlin, Khrushchev's Berlin ultimatum (1958), and the summit meetings of 1959–61. • The impact of the Cuban Revolution on relations with the USA and the Soviet Union, including the refusal of the USA to recognise Castro's government and the closer relations with the Soviet Union. The significance of the Bay of Pigs incident. • Opposition in Czechoslovakia to Soviet control: the Prague Spring.
2 Cold War crises	• The construction of the Berlin Wall, 1961. • The events of the Cuban Missile Crisis. • The Brezhnev Doctrine and the re-establishment of Soviet control in Czechoslovakia.
3 Reaction to crisis	• Impact of the construction of the Berlin Wall on US-Soviet relations. Kennedy's visit to West Berlin in 1963. • The consequences of the Cuban Missile Crisis, including the 'hotline'. Attempts at arms control: the Limited Test Ban Treaty (1963); the Outer Space Treaty (1967); and the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (1968). • International reaction to Soviet measures in Czechoslovakia.

Key topic 3: The end of the Cold War, 1970–91

1 Attempts to reduce superpower tensions in the 1970s	• Détente and attempts to reduce tensions in the 1970s. • The significance of SALT 1, the Helsinki Accords, and SALT 2.
2 The end of détente and the 'Second Cold War'	• The significance of the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan, the Carter Doctrine and the Olympic boycotts. • Reagan and the 'Second Cold War', the Strategic Defence Initiative (SDI). • The significance of Reagan and Gorbachev in reducing tensions.
3 The collapse of Soviet control of Eastern Europe, 1985-91	• The impact of Gorbachev's 'new thinking' on Eastern Europe: the loosening Soviet grip on Eastern Europe. • The significance of the fall of the Berlin Wall. • The collapse of the Soviet Union and its significance in bringing about the end of the Warsaw Pact.